

A report discusses how NHS satisfaction varies across different age groups, and the potential reasons for the change.

The satisfaction of NHS nowadays from different age groups

Abstract:

This study examines how satisfaction with the NHS varies by age group.

A qualitative study of the BSA 2019 data revealed that about 60% of respondents chose 'very satisfied' or 'quite satisfied' as their response choice. The percentage of these options increased from 54.1% (age group 18-25) to 67.9% (age group 65+). It demonstrates a positive correlation between age and NHS satisfaction; This report also uses qualitative analysis: a semi-structured interview with Zhihan. He believes that although young people themselves might not frequent hospitals, they would not feel less satisfied with the NHS than the elderly. Because they might have elderly relatives who are receiving benefits from the NHS. In addition, he prefers to describe NHS as health insurance so that young people won't be disappointed if they don't use it frequently. This report evaluates NHS performance and satisfaction rate nowadays, which helps the future improvement of public health services.

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Introduction:

The National Health System, or NHS, is a government-funded health organization that offers affordable or free medical treatment to all residents of the United Kingdom. This study tries to determine how comments made by UK citizens, residents, or any other NHS users on the NHS differ among age groups in recent years.

Established in 1948, NHS England, NHS Scotland, and NHS Wales are supported by general tax money (Vat, sales tax, etc.). People in Britain have had different opinions about the NHS throughout the past 70+ years. Some consider it to be an effective way to assure social welfare by addressing health issues and using tax money wisely. Others, however, could believe that the NHS is a monopoly that experiences problems with efficiency due to a lack of competition with any similar medical institutions. Some people may also express dissatisfaction with the lengthy wait times or poor services provided; While analyzing the causes for positive/negative assessments is useful. This research focuses more on the relationship between the perspective on the NHS and the age of the persons giving comments.

There is sufficient evidence proving that aggregate comment on the NHS remains positive, the most important piece of proof is the NHS's continued existence. The UK was ranked 18 out of 167 nations according to the data (democracy index) published by the EIU (Economist Intelligence Unit) in the weekly journal The Economist. (Democracy Index 2021 - The China challenge, 2022). The public would have more control over how the government should operate in a democratic country. The British public would not consent to the government using taxes inefficiently, especially not in the long run. The NHS has been in operation for more than 70 years, which confirms its worth and may indicate that the majority of citizens believe the government should use taxpayer money to preserve the NHS. As a result, the 1st hypothesis is demonstrated:

Hypothesis 1: Most of the population (all age groups) are satisfied with the NHS service

However, given the association between aging and the risk of contracting certain diseases, age may have large impact on how individuals feel about the NHS. In other words, older people are more prone than younger people to develop specific diseases. For instance, diabetes and CVD (cardiovascular disease) are the two most common ones. The analysis of CVD and stroke through a medical analysis reveals an age gradient. For people from age group

55-64, the relative risks (RRs) of developing CVD are doubled compared to the average or standard RRs. Similarly, the risk of stroke increases 2/3 folds for this age group people (Farshad et al., 2013). Since their bodies are less capable of fighting off bacteria and viruses, it is possible that older people have a higher risk of being sick. Therefore, opinions expressed about the NHS by different age groups might vary. More specifically, older individuals are more likely than younger individuals to gain access to NHS services. As a result, the 2nd hypothesis is as follows:

Hypothesis 2: The old would tend to be more satisfied with NHS nowadays than the youth.

Additionally, the extend of the difference in the comment is also tested. The resources gathered need to reveal a standing-out conclusion. The following hypothesis is relevant in testing this question:

Hypothesis 2(a): People from old age groups are much more satisfied with NHS than those from young age groups.

Data and Methods:

The report's open-ended questions are looked at using both quantitative and qualitative methods. The quantitative approach involves the analysis of secondary data from the BSA (British Social Attitudes 2019) survey, which gathers 3218 valid responses related to satisfaction with the NHS. A semi-structured interview with Zhihan, a 20-year-old Chinese man who lived in Manchester for more than a year, was done as the qualitative research approach. His experiences in public hospitals, including one stay of more than a month, ensured that he had a thorough understanding of the NHS system. His viewpoint on the relationship between NHS satisfaction and age would be explored in the interview.

While the BSA questionnaire's sample size is sufficient to generate a credible public opinion of the NHS, further modifications may be necessary to fit my report's problem and test my hypotheses. The responses available are: skip, item not applicable, very satisfied, quite satisfied, neither satisfied nor dissatisfied, quite dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, don't know, and refusal. The first step is to exclude the options that are not needed so that only 5 valid responses remain (very satisfied, quite satisfied, neither satisfied nor dissatisfied, and quite dissatisfied). Since this dataset is a nominal one, mean value, standard deviation, etc. are not valid for analysis. To understand the general opinion on NHS, the frequency analysis is most appropriate, which a bar chart and mode figure could demonstrate the result for 1st hypothesis.

However, the main issue discussed by the research is how satisfied NHS is with the age factor. To test hypotheses 2 and 2(a), it is necessary to introduce an age factor from the dataset and combine it with the previously mentioned NHS dataset. By doing so, a cross-tabulation outcome illustrating the extent of satisfaction with NHS from different age groups is created. The age ranges are 18-24, 25-34, 35-44, 45-54, 55-59, 60-64, and 65+. The most sufficient way to observe the change in opinions is to compare the percentages of the population from this age group of the same opinion. For instance, 20% of people from the age group 18-24 vote for very satisfied, and 40% of people who are 65+ vote for very satisfied shows the difference in opinions. By a detailed analysis of these differences, the 2nd hypothesis could be justified.

The interview with Zhihan will focus on his opinion of the NHS system based on his past experiences and his perspectives. He was familiarized with the topic of the interview and gave consent to use some of his private information. The interview was semi-structured, and a topic guide is previously prepared. For the sake of simplification, the interview is held in English. After that, the record is converted into text to make the analysis and review process easier. Also, by using a coding technique, useful information can be extracted from the recording during analysis. By adding a theme or conclusion to a long transcript, it is easier to understand the structure of the recording (text form). However, to gain more in-depth analysis, the coding framework needed to be done in a more detailed way: using sub-codes to develop more branches of the main code. This provides more information for analysis and helps to test hypotheses.

Results:

The frequency table of aggregate has been demonstrated in figure 1:

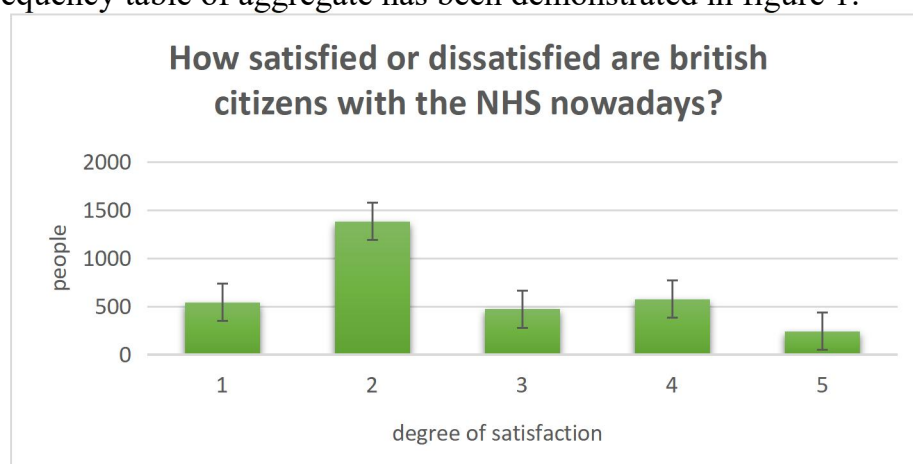


Figure.1

Source: BSA (British Social Attitudes 2019) Company Limited by Guarantee Registered in England No. 4392418

Valid sample size: N=3218

It is easy to witness that the mode of the dataset is 2, which means the most

popular response is 'quite satisfied'. 1384 out of 3218 people (43.0%) are quite satisfied with NHS services nowadays. Followed by 544 (16.9%) who are 'very satisfied', 472 people are neither satisfied nor dissatisfied (14.7%), 577 people are quite dissatisfied (17.9%) and 242 people are very dissatisfied (7.5%).

Because 60% of people are content with the NHS, hypothesis 1 is justified in being true. However, our research question introduces a new independent variable: age. As a result, figure 2 in the crosstab analysis displays the satisfaction of each age group with NHS.

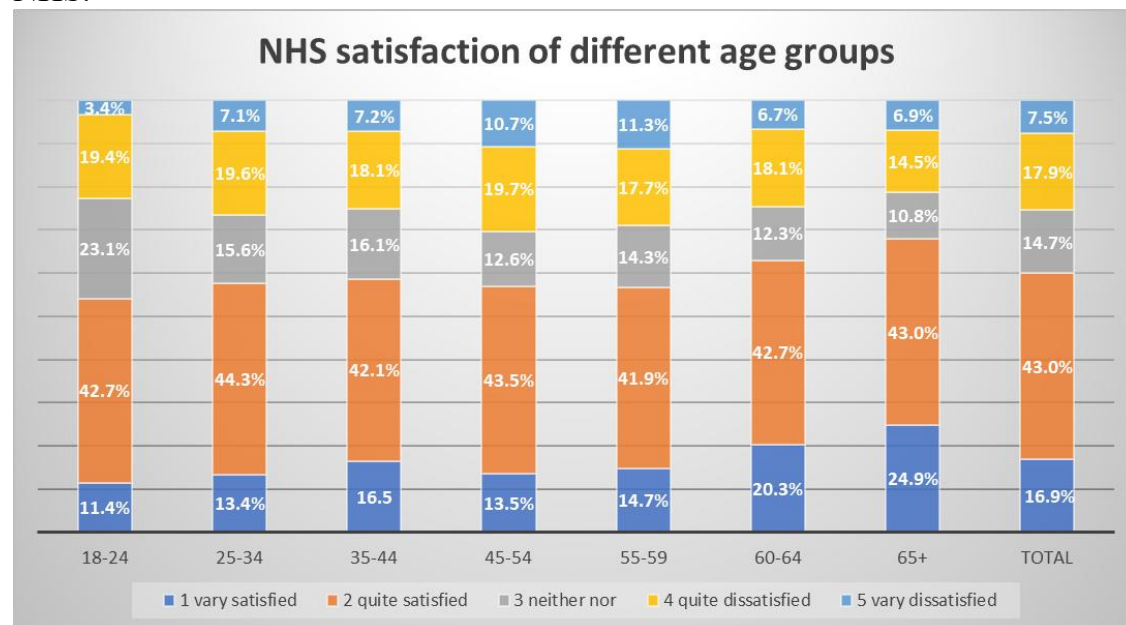


Figure.2

Source: BSA (British Social Attitudes 2019) Company Limited by Guarantee Registered in England No. 4392418

Valid sample size: Age 18-24 N=351, Age 25-34 N=553, Age 35-44 N=515, Age 45-54 N=563, Age 55-59 N=265, Age 60-64 N=227, Age 65+ N=744,

Different age groups are represented on the x-axis of this bar table, which uses different colors to indicate different satisfaction levels. However, given the sample sizes for each age group vary, comparing the magnitude of numbers can not conduct any constructive conclusions. Therefore, the percentage statistic has been labeled for every bar. For instance, the label of 11.4% on the dark blue bar of the 18-24 age group means the age group 18-24, 40 out of 351 people choose very satisfied, which takes 11.4% of the population of 351.

Comparing the % change of the same option across different age categories and comparing each percentage with the total percentage of the same option, could suggest the trend of changing perspectives. For instance, it is worth noting that the dark blue bar, which represents very satisfied has a large change in % across different age groups. It rises from 11.4% (18-24 age group) to 24.9%

(65+ age group). This increase of more than 10% in the option 'very satisfied' is quite large, which indicates that much more old people feel very satisfied with NHS than the youth in proportion. The figure 20.4% and 24.9% are also higher than the average percentage of 16.9%, which might suggest that there is a positive correlation between age and satisfaction with NHS. Hypothesis 2 might be justified.

However, the orange bar, which stands for quite satisfied only fluctuates a little around 42% or 43% in the figure. Weirdly, no obvious increase in satisfaction as age increases for the choice "quite satisfied". The highest is 44.3% (25-34 age group), which does not support the 2nd hypothesis. Likewise, the other bars change little. Thus, hypothesis 2(a) is supported to be wrong, for an increase in aggregate satisfaction is observed despite, the increase is not large.

To further develop NHS satisfaction and age problem, an interview with Zhihan is designed. Although Zhihan was not given the quantitative data results to avoid any potential confirmation bias, some of these observations were accidentally explained by the interview. These parts of the interview will be demonstrated and discussed. However, the discussion begins with his perspective on the NHS in general and his experience with it:

'I am satisfied with it, being honest. You know I was in hospital for half a month before, but I was charged little. And...I just have no reason to complain. The environment was not excellent but fine, the staff were good... I know many people complain about the waiting time, but my experience was fine. Maybe I am lucky.'

When discussing the issue of fairness, he believes that older people would benefit more from NHS services while younger people would pay more tax. This opinion is later justified by many articles that a large proportion of the NHS budget is spent on old people. For instance, 2/5 of the NHS budget was spent on the age group 65+ in the UK in 2013/2014 (Delphine, 2016). However, he gives a new explanation for the fairness problem.

'I actually don't think this would have any problem... emm, I know that old people are more likely to be sick, but you'll have to consider about the family issue, right? Sure, NHS is kind of like young people

ah...paying tax to support the health care of the old...and themselves of course. But most family, the young people would have their own parents and grandparents that needs healthcare. I don't think there would be many young people feel not fair about that, cause they'll pay their healthcare fees anyway...if not NHS, they may cost more'

He thinks young people are not judging NHS services only from their own experiences, but also consider their family members' experiences. This could be the cause of why our data do not demonstrate a substantial decline in satisfaction when age decreases. Even those who don't frequently visit public hospitals will still be happy with the NHS because they don't have to spend much on the medical care of their elderly relatives.

Also, he added another explanation:

'Just like I said, old visit public hospital more than young, but I don't really think this is gonna make young people feel bad. Because... NHS is just like an insurance in health. If you buy a car insurance, you won't say you are disappointed because you don't have any car accidents during the period insurance cover, right? Ha-ha, I think so as NHS, it is a health insurance to guarantee you do not get...bankrupted because of a serious illness.'

By combining the outcome of quantitative data and qualitative data, the results justify hypothesis 1 and hypothesis 2 but reject hypothesis 2(a). As people get older, they may be more satisfied with NHS, but the extent is not as great as anticipated.

Conclusion:

This report analyses the relevance of NHS satisfaction with the age factor, after analyzing quantitative data of the BSA survey, it is discovered most people are satisfied with the NHS (60% give a positive response, about 15% of people

give a neutral respond). However, despite the satisfaction rate increasing as age groups get older, the increasing scale is not extremely large.

In the conversation, Zhihan discusses his opinions on age and the satisfaction of the NHS. He acknowledges that the elderly would be more satisfied, but he does not believe there could be a strong association between these factors. His opinions are more rooted in reality, considering what people would do or think in real life. These useful ideas aid in the explanation of several quantitative data phenomena. Why, for instance, does age not have a substantial impact on the growth in NHS satisfaction?

There may have been limitations about this report, though. As a result of Zhihan's limited exposure to the NHS outside of Manchester, his perspective on the hospital environment, wait times, quality, and other factors may not be accurate. Besides, as a 20-year-old student, Zhihan's perspective regarding the elderly receiving NHS is based solely on common sense and may not be accurate. To solve this, more interviews with participants from various age groups could help to lessen bias and increase accuracy. Regarding qualitative data, the 65+ age group might be further divided into the following categories: 65-70, 71-80, and 80+. Because those who are older might have different perspectives on the NHS.

The improvement of NHS could be more easily made by improving the satisfaction of young people, for the old are already quite satisfied with NHS compared to young people. The satisfaction rate for younger age groups is slightly over 50%, which shows a great potential improvement could be made. The government could provide more financial support to them, and the hospital could upgrade machines that are mostly used by young people. For instance, the ultrasound machine is commonly used for young pregnant women. These could help to improve the satisfaction of young people.

In conclusion, this study discusses the relationship between age and NHS satisfaction, and it is revealed that the two variables are positively correlated. that as people get older, they are more satisfied with the NHS.

Bibliography:

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Appendix:

[Announcements]:

1. Ask for the consent of interviewee for using their background information.
2. Ask for the agreement of recording the interview conversation.
3. Briefly introduce the project

[Personal information]:

1. Nationality, age, gender
2. Place now live and Job
3. Past medical records (e.g., surgery history)

[Participant's experience about NHS]:

1. Describe how NHS runs and introducing the past experiences in NHS:
when, where, for what reason.
 - 1(a) waiting time
 - 1(b) environment and quality
 - 1(c) Just from appearance, are there more old people or young people or approximately equal.
2. Talking about your longest stay in NHS, reason and how do you feel.
3. Which services are free, and which are not (e.g., are staying in hospital free?
Are drugs free provided?)

[Participant's perspective about NHS]:

1. General perspectives about NHS services, satisfied or dissatisfied.
 - 1(a). The reasons for satisfaction/dissatisfaction
 - 1(b). Has your opinion ever changed in the past?
2. Do you think older people or younger people are more likely to be benefited by NHS services.
 - 2(a) reason for that, do you feel it is unfair? (Either old or young)
3. Is it a wise and efficient way to spend tax revenue on NHS?
 - 3(a) Do you think young people or old people contributes to the major tax revenue.
 - 3(b) (if the respond of 2 and 3(a) are different) Do you think it is fair for young/old generation paying more tax but receiving less NHS services.